

Lifestyle hazards

Pregnancy can be beset with anxiety about potential hazards. Being aware of exactly what to avoid will help to allay fears.

Whether you're pregnant or are planning to conceive, now is the time to do a safety check on your social habits and home and work environment. Anything that could affect your well-being could affect your baby too, especially in the first trimester. Don't become overanxious, but arm yourself with the facts so that you can avoid hazards and enjoy your pregnancy.

Your social habits

The decision to have a baby may inspire you to review your social habits and, if necessary, make changes.

Alcohol consumption You should stop drinking alcohol while trying to get pregnant and once you're pregnant according to the US Surgeon General. There is no known safe consumption level for pregnant women, so abstaining from drinking is the safest option. What isn't in doubt is the damage caused to the fetus by excessive alcohol intake and could lead to [fetal alcohol syndrome](#). The effects include retarded growth, facial and joint abnormalities, and heart problems.

If you drank in the weeks before you knew you were pregnant, try not to worry, but stop now. Many women also decide to give up alcohol while they're trying to conceive to optimize fertility.

Smoking Ideally, stop smoking before you get pregnant. If you're still smoking once you conceive, stop right away. If your partner or friends smoke, ask them not to smoke in your home or near you. Inhaled cigarette smoke interferes with the supply of oxygen to the baby, which can lead to a low birthweight and increases the risk of stillbirth or the death of a baby in the first month of life. If you smoke in pregnancy, you will be advised to take low-dose aspirin and offered smoking cessation classes. The doctor will also monitor your carbon monoxide levels, which is especially dangerous as it reduces the amount of oxygen available to the baby and may affect the baby's growth.

Recreational drug use In addition to damaging your own health, recreational drugs are not advised in pregnancy since some pose dangers for the fetus and other hazards.

Heroin and cocaine are damaging to both a pregnant woman and her unborn baby. These drugs stunt fetal growth, affect the placenta, and can cause miscarriage or premature birth, as well as health problems in the newborn. Babies born to women who use heroin often show drug withdrawal symptoms. A report on ecstasy linked the use of this in pregnancy to a rise in birth defects. The specific effects of amphetamines and LSD are unclear, but it's safest to avoid them.

Although marijuana may be legal in some states, use of marijuana in pregnancy and breastfeeding is not safe for your baby. Using marijuana, in any of its forms, can cause problems with your baby's developing brain as well as low birthweight.

Hazards at home

Many people use chemicals daily in and around the home, contained in toiletries and cleaning products. When products are used in accordance with the manufacturers' instructions, there is little chance of them causing harm in pregnancy. However, minute traces of chemicals can enter the bloodstream, either through the skin or by